1. Purpose

To establish a rigorous, standardized framework for the end-to-end management of food products—spanning initial receipt, strategic storage, and final issuance—to ensure total operational consistency. By implementing uniform procedures across all storage environments, the organization effectively mitigates the risk of premature spoilage and optimizes inventory turnover, thereby minimizing the fiscal impact of preventable waste. Furthermore, this systematic approach serves as a critical quality control mechanism, providing an absolute guarantee that only ingredients maintaining peak safety profiles and high-quality specifications are utilized in food preparation, ultimately safeguarding both public health and the establishment's culinary reputation.

2. Scope

Governs the complete lifecycle of all inventory—encompassing raw ingredients, packaging materials, in-house prepared sub-assemblies, and finished goods—from the exact moment of receipt at the loading dock through to final culinary service or disposal. It applies universally across all store, facility, and storage environments, including dry storerooms, walk-in chillers, deep freezers, and active prep line stations. By defining these boundaries, the procedure ensures that every single item is systematically rotated based primarily on its critical expiration date (FEFO) or, in the absence of a printed date, its chronological order of receipt (FIFO), thereby guaranteeing food safety, maximizing product and meal quality, and drastically reducing preventable spoilage across the entire operation.

3. Responsibilities

3.1. Warehousing and Receiving Employee/ Kitchen Employee

Shall be responsible for accurately labelling all incoming goods and stocking shelves back-to-front according to FEFO principles. Shall also be responsible for pulling items strictly from the front of the shelf and ensuring internal prep items are correctly labeled with discard dates.

3.2. Supply Chain Supervisor/ Restaurant Manager/ Kitchen Captain

Shall be responsible for conducting daily visual inspections of storage areas to ensure older is being pulled and labels are compliant.

4. Definition of Terms

- **First In, First Out (FIFO):** The principle that the items received earliest are the ones used first. This is typically used for items without printed expiration dates, like fresh produce or house-made prepped items.
- **First Expiry, First Out (FEFO):** The principle that the items with the earliest expiration or use-by date are used first, regardless of when they were received. FEFO always overrides FIFO.
- **High-Risk Commodities:** Inventory groups—specifically encompassing proteins, dairy products, and prepared sub-assemblies—that are highly vulnerable to microbial proliferation and biochemical breakdown.
- **In-House Prepared Sub-Assemblies (Internal Prep Items):** Food elements prepped directly within the facility that do not have manufacturer dates and must be explicitly labeled with mandatory discard dates.
- **Improper Stocking:** An operational error where new inventory is incorrectly placed in front of older stock, directly violating standard FEFO/FIFO rotation sequence.

- **Retraining Event:** A formal corrective action documented in an employee's file following a rotation mistake, used to establish a verifiable audit trail and reinforce kitchen discipline.

5. Principles

The First In, First Out (FIFO) principle constitutes the fundamental chronological framework of inventory management, predicated on the requirement that goods be utilized in the exact sequence of their acquisition. In high-output culinary environments, this methodology mitigates the risk of inventory stagnation by ensuring that existing stock is physically prioritized at the point of selection, while subsequent shipments are staged behind current supplies. This methodical rotation maintains inventory in a consistent state of optimal turnover. While primarily applied to non-perishable commodities or items lacking manufacturer-specified expiration dates, FIFO's critical utility lies in facilitating a lean, organized storage infrastructure where product obsolescence—resulting from the accumulation of overlooked or obstructed stock—is systematically eliminated.

Conversely, the First Expiry, First Out (FEFO) principle serves as a critical safeguard within a Food Safety Management System (FSMS), prioritizing a product's designated shelf-life over its date of procurement. Within the FSMS framework, FEFO maintains operational precedence over FIFO; should an inventory item possess an imminent expiration date, it must be transitioned to the primary selection area for immediate utilization, irrespective of its arrival sequence. This methodology is imperative for high-risk commodities—including proteins, dairy products, and prepared sub-assemblies—as it directly mitigates the risks associated with microbial proliferation and biochemical degradation. By adhering to FEFO, the organization ensures that consumer safety and regulatory compliance are never compromised for the sake of mere chronological sequencing.

6. Procedures

6.1. Receiving and Labeling

- **Accurate Labeling:** All incoming inventory—encompassing raw ingredients, packaging materials, and finished goods—must be accurately labeled immediately upon arrival at the loading dock.
- **Internal Prep Items:** Any in-house prepared sub-assemblies or internal prep items must be explicitly labeled with calculated discard dates before being moved to storage.

6.2. Strategic Storage and Shelf Stacking

- **The FEFO Rule:** Inventory items possessing an expiration or use-by date must be systematically rotated based on that critical date. Items with the closest expiration dates must be transitioned to the primary selection area for immediate utilization, regardless of when they arrived. FEFO always maintains operational precedence over FIFO.
- **The FIFO Rule:** In the absence of a printed manufacturer expiration date (such as with fresh produce, non-perishable commodities, or house-made prepped items), stock must be rotated chronologically based on its exact date of receipt.
- **Back-to-Front Stocking:** When stocking dry storerooms, walk-in chillers, deep freezers, and active prep line stations, employees must physically stage new shipments behind current supplies. Shelves must be stocked from back-to-front so that older inventory is physically prioritized and pushed to the front of the shelf.

6.3. Inventory Issuance

- **Front-Row Selection:** Kitchen and warehousing employees must pull items strictly from the front of the shelf to ensure older stock is utilized first and to eliminate the risk of overlooked or obstructed stock.

7. Corrective Action

In the event that expired stock is discovered, immediate isolation is mandatory to prevent accidental usage, followed by a formal entry in the ***IQAF-007:Spoilage/Waste Tracker*** to ensure financial transparency and facilitate trend analysis prior to disposal. Should a manager/ supervisor identify improper stocking—specifically new inventory placed in front of older stock—they must execute an immediate intervention by requiring the responsible employee to physically reorder the items according to FEFO/FIFO protocols. This corrective phase is only complete once the manager documents the incident as a retraining event in the employee's file, transforming a simple rotation error into a verifiable audit trail that reinforces operational discipline and prevents the systemic accumulation of "invisible" waste.

8. Verification

To maintain strict oversight of the storage environments the Restaurant Manager, Shift Manager, or Kitchen Captain is required to conduct mandatory daily visual inspections across all store storage areas. These routine inspections serve as active compliance checks to explicitly verify that older stock is being pulled first and that all inventory labels—including mandatory internal discard dates on prepped items—are fully compliant with established FEFO and FIFO rotation principles. By physically auditing the dry storerooms, chest freezers, showcase chiller, 4-door freezer refrigerator, and active prep lines, leadership ensures that potential stocking errors are caught early and that high-risk commodities are handled safely before reaching food preparation.

9. Change History

Revision No.:	Revision Date:	Author & Position:	Purpose of Revision
0	February 23, 2026	Marielle Louise Macabale**, QA Specialist**	Originator
1	March 05, 2026	Marielle Louise Macabale**, QA Specialist**	• Change the addressing of personnel; staff members to employees • Added IQAF-004:Spoilage/ Waste Tracker to corrective action provision • Added additional signatory; L&D Manager
2	June 2, 2026	Celine Joy Sanchez**, QA Specialist**	• Added Definition of Terms, Procedures and Verification

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